

Richmond Park - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Deer of Richmond Park

Keep your eyes open — somewhere in this park, about six hundred deer are watching you. Richmond Park is London's biggest royal park, and the deer have lived here for almost four hundred years, ever since King Charles the First fenced it off as his private hunting ground in 1637. There are two kinds: red deer, which are big and shaggy like small horses, and fallow deer, which are smaller with white spots. Here's the rule — stay at least fifty meters away, about half a football pitch. They look calm, but a stag's antlers can grow a meter wide, and he sheds them and grows a brand-new pair every single year. Imagine growing new bones out of your head every summer! The antlers grow up to two centimeters a day, some of the fastest-growing bone on Earth. In autumn, the stags bellow and clash antlers to show off, but in July they're peaceful, munching grass in the bracken. Fun challenge: fallow deer bounce with all four feet off the ground at once when startled. It's called "pronking." If you spot one doing it, you win the walk.

Baby Deer in the Bracken

Here is a secret about the time of year you're visiting. Right now, in early summer, there are baby deer hidden all around this park, and you probably won't see a single one. That's exactly how it's supposed to be. The mothers give birth from May into July, more than two hundred babies every year, and a newborn fawn can't run yet. For its first week or two it can barely walk. So the mother does something very clever. She tucks her baby down low in the tall grass or the ferny bracken, tells it to stay still, and walks away to graze nearby. The fawn lies frozen, curled up, not moving a muscle, even if you walked right past it.

Why does that keep it safe? Because a newborn fawn is born almost completely without a smell. Think about that. A fox or a dog hunts mostly with its nose, and a scentless baby lying perfectly still is almost invisible. The mother even licks her fawn clean and eats everything left behind, so there's nothing to sniff out. Then, a few times a day, she comes quietly back to feed it and groom it, and slips away again. It looks like the baby has been abandoned. It absolutely has not. Mum knows exactly where it is.

So here is the most important rule of your whole walk, and it's a rule even grown-ups sometimes get wrong. If you ever find a fawn lying alone in the grass, do not touch it. Do not pick it up. Don't even go close. If you leave your smell on it, or scare the mother away, you can put it in real danger. The kindest thing you can do is back away quietly and feel proud that you spotted one at all.

This is also why, from the first of May to the end of July, every dog in the park has to stay on a lead. A curious dog crashing through the bracken is the last thing a hidden fawn needs. The whole park quietly rearranges itself around these babies, and most visitors never even know it's happening.

When they're a little older, watch for the fawns learning to play. They chase each other in wobbly circles, test out their legs, and practice that four-footed bouncy jump. A fallow fawn has creamy white spots down its back, like someone flicked a paintbrush over it, and those spots are camouflage too, breaking up its shape in the dappled light under the trees. Keep your eyes soft and your feet on the path, and you just might catch one taking its very first proper leaps across the grass.

Monsters in the Dead Wood

Now look away from the deer for a moment and find an old, old oak tree. Some of the oaks in this park are older than the park itself, hundreds of years old, so wide that you and your whole family holding hands couldn't reach around one. And here's the strange part. The most exciting creature in Richmond Park doesn't live on those grand old trees. It lives inside the dead and rotting ones, in the crumbly wood that most people would clear away as rubbish.

It's the stag beetle, and it is the biggest beetle in all of Britain. A big male can be as long as your finger, up to seven centimeters, shiny black and reddish brown, with enormous curved jaws on his head that look exactly like a stag's antlers. That's how he got his name. He even fights other males with them, wrestling and trying to flip his rival onto his back, just like the real deer clash their real antlers. But here's the twist, and it's a good one. Those giant jaws are mostly for showing off. They're so big and heavy he can barely give you a proper nip. The females, with much smaller jaws, are the ones who can actually pinch.

Here is the yucky, wonderful secret of the stag beetle's life. Before it ever becomes a beetle, it spends years, sometimes as long as six or seven years, as a fat, curled-up, cream-colored grub living underground inside rotting wood. All that time, in the dark, it does one job. It eats dead wood. Munch, munch, munch, slowly turning old logs back into rich soil. Then, after all those years hidden away, it finally changes into a beetle, digs its way out on a warm summer evening, spreads a pair of wings you'd never guess it had, and goes clattering off through the air looking for a mate. And after all that waiting, the grown-up beetle lives just a few short weeks.

Richmond Park is one of the best places in the whole of Europe for stag beetles, so special that it's protected just for them, and it's all thanks to that dead wood. When a great old oak drops a branch or finally falls, the park rangers often leave it lying right where it landed. To us it looks messy. To a stag beetle, a fallen log is a nursery, a dining room, and a home for the next seven years.

So on a warm evening here, keep an eye on the air around the oaks. If you see something big and clumsy droning past like a tiny flying tank, you've just met a monster that spent most of its life as a grub in a log. Give it a cheer. It waited a very long time for that flight.

A Whole Wild World in the City

Here's something amazing to remember as you walk. You are standing in the middle of one of the biggest cities on Earth, with millions of people all around you, and yet this park is officially a National Nature Reserve, two and a half thousand acres of proper wild countryside that just happens to sit inside London. Once you know that, you start noticing all the wildness hiding in plain sight.

First, listen. On a sunny day, stop and look straight up. You might hear a tiny bird pouring out a song so fast and bubbly it almost never stops to breathe. That's a skylark, and it does something incredible. It flies straight up into the sky, higher and higher until it's just a speck you can barely see, and sings the whole way, sometimes for minutes without a pause, before parachuting back down. Skylarks build their nests right on the ground, hidden in the grass, which makes them very easy to step on by accident. So the park sets aside special skylark areas, near a field by the ponds, where people are asked to keep to the paths. If you hear that song raining down from above, you're hearing one of the countryside's most magical sounds, in the middle of London.

Now find the water. In the heart of the park are the Pen Ponds, two big lakes joined by a path across the middle. People dug them out way back in 1746, hundreds of years ago, digging for gravel to build with, and then the water moved in and so did the wildlife. Herons stand there like grey statues waiting to stab a fish, ducks and geese paddle about, and cormorants dry their wings in the breeze. It's the perfect spot to stop and just watch for a while.

And if you'd visited in spring, there's a secret garden tucked inside the woods called the Isabella Plantation. For a few weeks in late April and May it absolutely explodes with color, thousands of azalea and rhododendron flowers in hot pink, orange, red, and purple, all reflected in still ponds and winding streams. Some of those azaleas came all the way from Japan. In July the fireworks are over, but it's still a cool, green, shady maze, a lovely place to escape the sun.

Here's the best part. A very famous man agrees with you that this place is special. Sir David Attenborough, the wildlife presenter you may have seen on television, has lived right beside this park for around seventy years, and he calls it his favorite escape in all of London. He even made a whole film about it. So as you walk, remember, you're exploring the same wild park that one of the greatest nature-watchers in the world calls home.

King Henry's Mound and the Secret Keyhole

You're standing on a small hill with a very big secret. This is King Henry's Mound, and the story goes that King Henry the Eighth stood right here in 1536, waiting to see a rocket fired from the Tower of London — the signal that his wife Anne Boleyn had been executed, so he was free to marry someone new. Henry had six wives in total, and things ended badly for quite a few of them. Now for the secret: find the telescope and look through the gap in the hedge. Ten miles away, you can see the dome of St Paul's Cathedral, perfectly framed by trees, like looking through a keyhole across all of London. This view is so special it's protected by law — nobody is allowed to build anything that blocks it, and it's been protected for over three hundred years. Skyscraper builders in London have to check their plans against this exact spot. You'll walk right up to that dome tomorrow — today you can see it the way people saw it centuries ago: tiny, floating above the trees, ten miles away.

Related listening: The same Henry the Eighth of the mound legend took Hampton Court from Cardinal Wolsey. Coming up — “The Palace a King Took for Himself” (Hampton Court Palace, Day 7).

The True Story Behind the Legend

So you've heard the story. King Henry the Eighth, standing on this very hill, watching for a puff of smoke from the Tower of London, waiting for the signal that his wife Anne Boleyn had lost her head so he could go and marry someone new. It's a chilling story, and it's the reason this place is called King Henry's Mound. But here's a question worth asking. Is it actually true? And the honest answer is, almost certainly not.

Let's start with what really did happen, because that part is real, and it's sad. Anne Boleyn was Henry's second wife, and once he'd decided he wanted to marry someone else, he had her accused of terrible crimes she almost certainly never committed. On the nineteenth of May, 1536, she was executed at the Tower of London. Henry did one strange, small thing that people call a mercy. Instead of an axe, which was clumsy and often took several blows, he sent all the way to France for an expert swordsman, so it would be quick. And just eleven days later, Henry married his next wife, Jane Seymour. Eleven days. He clearly wasn't heartbroken.

But was he standing on this hill, ten miles away, watching for a signal? Here's the problem. Historians who study Henry's life, reading old letters and records that say where the king was on which day, think he was nowhere near here. He was most likely far away in the countryside, in Wiltshire, waiting for the news to reach him there. And think about it, could anyone really see a small signal from the Tower of London ten miles away, or hear a cannon boom across the whole of London? Not really. The story just doesn't add up.

So where did the legend come from? Nobody's quite sure, and that's what makes it fun. Sometimes a place gets a dramatic story pinned to it long, long after the real events, and because the story is so gripping, people repeat it for hundreds of years until it feels like the truth. It's a bit like a rumor at school that grows bigger every time it's passed along. Somewhere down the centuries, someone looked at this old hill with its wide view toward London and thought, wouldn't it be perfect if the king had watched from here. And the name stuck.

This is actually a brilliant thing to know as a traveler. Almost everywhere you visit will have stories like this, exciting tales that might be totally true, partly true, or completely made up. The trick isn't to stop enjoying them. The trick is to enjoy the story and stay curious enough to ask, I wonder if that really

happened. So stand here, picture the scene if you like, but now you know the real secret of King Henry's Mound. The best part of the story is figuring out which bits are legend.

The House Where a Great Thinker Grew Up

Look around you, near the top of the mound, and you'll spot a handsome old house with a wide terrace and beautiful gardens. That's Pembroke Lodge, and King Henry's Mound actually sits right inside its grounds. This house has a story that's every bit as interesting as the mound, and it's completely true, which makes a nice change.

A long time ago, in 1847, Queen Victoria herself gave this house to a man named Lord John Russell. And Lord John wasn't just anybody. He was the Prime Minister, the leader of the whole country, a bit like a president. He ran important government business from right here, in a house in the middle of a deer park. Imagine the most powerful meetings in the land happening while deer wandered past the windows. All sorts of famous people came to visit him here, including Charles Dickens, the writer who wrote *A Christmas Carol*, and a famous soldier from Italy called Garibaldi.

But here's the part I really want you to remember. Lord John had a grandson, a little boy named Bertrand. When Bertrand was just four years old, something very sad happened. Both of his parents died. So the little orphaned boy came to live here, at Pembroke Lodge, with his grandparents, and he grew up right here in this park, running through these same gardens, climbing this same hill, staring out at this same enormous view.

And that little boy grew up to become one of the most famous thinkers in the whole world. His name was Bertrand Russell, and he became a brilliant mathematician and philosopher, which is a person whose actual job is to think very hard about the biggest questions there are. Questions like, how do we know what's really true? What makes something right or wrong? He won one of the greatest prizes in the world for his writing, and people still read his ideas today, more than a hundred years later.

Isn't that something to think about? A shy little boy, sad and lonely after losing his parents, wandering these exact lawns where you're standing now, looking out at the same trees and the same faraway dome of St Paul's. Nobody walking past him back then could have guessed that this quiet child would grow up to change how people all over the world think.

So while you're up here, take a slow look at that house and those gardens. This isn't just a spot with a famous view. It's a place where a real prime minister ran a country, and where a lonely little boy grew into a genius. Parks like this one are full of hidden stories like that, tucked into the corners, just waiting for a curious traveler to come along and find them.

Now Turn Around

You've peeked through the keyhole in the hedge and found the tiny dome of St Paul's ten miles away. That's the famous view, the one that's protected by law. But now do something most visitors forget to do. Turn all the way around and look the other way.

Behind you, the land drops down and opens up into a huge, wide sweep of green, the whole valley of the River Thames rolling away to the west. No skyscrapers, no traffic, just trees and grass and sky stretching as far as you can see. And here's the wonderful thing. This is why this hill has mattered to people for thousands of years. From up here, you can see anyone or anything coming for miles in every direction. That's incredibly useful if you're a king who wants to go hunting, or a lookout watching the land, or a person long, long ago choosing a special place high above everything else.

Because remember, this mound is much, much older than King Henry. Long before there were kings named Henry, before knights, before castles, ancient people probably built this hill thousands of years ago.

Many people think it was a burial mound, a special place to lay someone important to rest, raised up high so it could be seen and remembered. Then, over the centuries, people used it as a lookout, a place to watch for deer, to fly hunting birds called falcons, and just to stand and take in the view. So many different people, across so many years, all drawn to the same little hill for the same simple reason. From up here, you can see the world.

And that brings us to tomorrow. See that faraway dome one more time, through the keyhole, floating above the trees. It looks tiny from here, doesn't it, small enough to hide behind your thumb. But tomorrow, you're going to stand right underneath it. That dome belongs to St Paul's Cathedral, and up close it is gigantic, one of the biggest domes in the world, so tall it was the highest thing in all of London for hundreds of years. The whole reason you can still see it from this exact spot is that people fought to keep the view clear, so that a person standing on this ancient hill would always be able to spot it.

So here's your mission for the trip. Really look at it now, tiny and far away and magical. Then, when you're standing beneath it tomorrow, with your neck craned all the way back, remember this moment on the hill. Same dome. Two completely different ways of seeing it. That's one of the best tricks of traveling, seeing the same thing twice, and understanding it a little more each time.